Busy vs Effective

Why "being busy" is not a good signal and what actually moves the needle.

> "If everything feels urgent, nothing actually is."

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The Busy Trap

Most people confuse motion with progress.

Busy ≠ Effective

Filling your calendar is not the same as making meaningful progress on what matters.

Reactive by Default

Without a prioritisation system, you respond to whatever arrives loudest — not what matters most.

Busyness as Identity

We've normalised "I'm swamped" as a status signal. It's often a sign of poor filters, not high value.

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Why It Happens

Urgency is loud. Importance is quiet. Our brains respond to the loudest signal.

🔔 Urgent

Feels pressing *right now*. Triggers a stress response. Usually someone else's priority imposed on you — with a deadline attached.

🎯 Important

Moves your actual goals forward. Often has no deadline. Easy to deprioritise. Nobody is chasing you — so it waits indefinitely.

⚠ No decision filter means defaulting to urgency. Your time flows to whoever asks loudest.

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The Decision Filter

Before saying yes to any task, run it through these four questions.

1

Does this move my actual goal forward?

If the answer is "sort of", it's a no.

2

What breaks if I don't do this today?

Real urgency has real consequences. Manufactured urgency rarely does.

3

Am I the right person for this?

Delegate or decline what isn't uniquely yours to do.

4

Is this a distraction dressed as progress?

Reorganising your Notion is not deep work.

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Real-World Examples

The same situation, two different responses. One is busy. One is effective.

Reactive — The Meeting Spiral

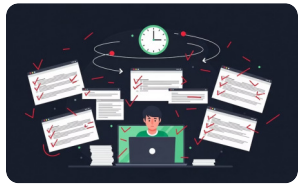
Designer spends 3 hours in meetings about a feature shipping in 6 months. Skips the portfolio update due this week.

BUSY

Effective — The Morning Block

Same designer blocks 2 hours each morning for high-leverage work. Responds to others in batched windows.

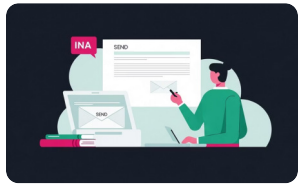
EFFECTIVE



Reactive — The Endless Revision

Keeps revising the same deck because "it could always be better." Delays the actual send indefinitely.

BUSY



Effective — The 90% Ship

Ships a 90% deck today. Iterates based on real feedback — not internal loops that never end.

EFFECTIVE

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How to Stop Being Busy

Five shifts that move you from reactive to deliberate.

01

Set 1–3 weekly priorities before the week starts

Not 12. Three maximum — or you have none.

02

Block deep work time before your calendar fills

If it's not scheduled, it won't happen.

03

Apply the decision filter before every new commitment

Does it move the needle — or just feel productive?

04

Say no to urgency that isn't yours to own

Most fires extinguish themselves.

05

End each day with one honest question

"Did I move my actual goal forward today?"

Stop measuring your day in tasks completed. Measure it in ground covered toward what actually matters.

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